First, just the facts, ma'am. A lurid murder-themed book launch in South Delhi becomes the scene for two murders. Victim one is DB, the Communist-minded editor of a Delhi tabloid. Victim two is Anika Kapoor, columnist at the said tabloid and the bratty daughter of its gazillionaire owners.

Although Anika appeared to have enemies, DB was a nice, old man, with a modest income and despised by no one in particular. Suspects include characters from the Delhi publishing and journalism scene. The police want to wrap up the case quickly. But when two of the tabloid's journalists, the misanthropic Mridula and her younger assistant Monami, start playing detective, everybody gets on high alert.

Samyukta Bhowmick's first novel *A Fatal Distraction* is a highly entertaining and heart-warming throwback to Agatha Christie's best works. Bhowmick tips her hat to Christie throughout the plot. There's the matter of everybody having a motive to bump off Anika, much like the passengers in *Murder on the Orient Express*. A short window of opportunity between two murders, the murder happening much earlier than it is initially believed to have occurred and the denouement involving shoes are straight out of *The Murder of Roger Ackroyd*.

Bhowmick creates highly compelling three-dimensional characters out of what initially seem to be clichés

And just about any number of characters in a Hercule Poirot story pretend to be someone else. There's, of course, upfront and centre, Monami, a nod to Poirot's endearing "mon ami", meaning 'my friend' in French.

But do not for a second think Bhowmick's novel is just a fangirl's tribute to her favourite writer. Bhowmick creates highly compelling three-dimensional characters out of what initially seem to be clichés (snooty Delhi one-percenters, high-strung journos working out of ITO). The psychological depth in the relationships between old lovers, sisters, fathers and daughters lends the novel a melancholic weight, that made me care for the characters and kept me invested till the end.

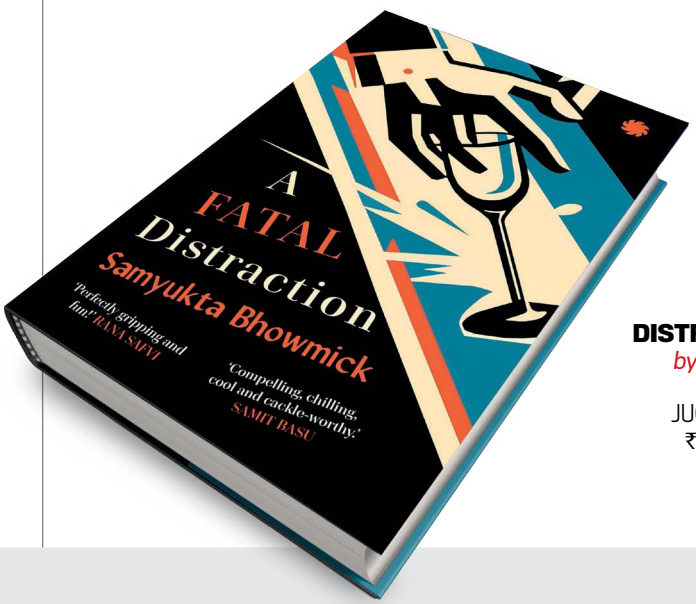
Above all, Bhowmick's handling of Anika is exquisite. The *Rashomon*-like conflicting perspectives from the suspects about what happened on the night of the crime and the full picture of Anika emerging from everyone's accounts make her a blockbuster character. If a film adaptation happens, actors should gun for her role. Anika is the only character who keeps changing from scene to scene by design.

What's amusing also is relating to the particularities of Delhi newsrooms and publishing scene, easily apparent to anybody who has spent any time in these worlds. Some clever but harmless references to real-life journalism and publishing figures brought to mind Aditya Sinha's 2017 crime novel *The CEO Who Lost His Head*.

What's unconvincing early on is Mridula and Monami investigating the crime, leaving behind their day jobs, when nobody has tasked them with the probe. Forensics are also conspicuously absent in what is ultimately a contemporary story, despite operating within a literary tradition's rules. Mridula and Monami also needed some meat, some personality, some inner life. Perhaps, more books in this series will take care of that. ■ **–Devarsi Ghosh**

MURDERS MOST **FOUL**

SAMYUKTA BHOWMICK'S *DEBUT NOVEL,* A FATAL DISTRACTION, *IS A WHODUNIT THAT GOES BEYOND MERELY PAYING TRIBUTE TO THE MASTERS OF THE GENRE*



A FATAL DISTRACTION
by Samyukta Bhowmick
JUGGERNAUT
₹599; 320 pages